Nell and the Pocket-Sized Storm

CHAPTER 1

Weather in a Boot

Nell's left boot said, "Excuse me."

Nell stopped putting on her right boot.

"Grandma?"

"In the kitchen," called Grandma.

Nell peered into the left boot. Two small eyes peered back.

"There is a pebble in here," said a cross little voice. "And I appear to be sitting on it."

Nell tipped the boot upside down.

A pebble fell out.

Then the weather fell out.

It was a cloud the size of a bread roll. It had a gray belly, fluffy eyebrows, and a piece of yellow sock stuck to its bottom.

Nell pulled off the sock.

"Thank you," said the cloud. "It was itching."

"You're a cloud."

"A pocket storm, actually. My name is Grumble."

Nell held out her hand. Grumble settled on her palm.

Her sleeve immediately became damp.

"Do you live in boots?" Nell asked.

"Only by accident. I smelled toast, followed it down a chimney, and got lost."

"That happens to me with cake. Except for the chimney."

Grumble stood on tiptoe. At least, his bottom grew two little points.

Through the open window, Nell could see a line of clouds beyond the hill.

"My family," he said. "They'll cross the hills at sunset. I have to catch them."

Nell carried him into the kitchen.
Grandma looked up from buttering toast.
"Well," she said. "I thought that boot was unusually rainy."
Grumble bowed. Three drops landed in the butter.
"Sorry."
Grandma fetched a saucer.
"All guests get something to sit on."
Nell wanted to ask a hundred questions. Did clouds have birthdays? Did lightning tickle?
But Grumble was watching the window.
"We'll help you get home," she said.

In the garden, Nell lifted him over her head.

"Off you go!"

Grumble floated down and landed on her nose.

"Cold," said Nell.

"Sorry," said Grumble.

He peeled himself off.

"Pocket storms need a proper breeze to rise high. It's too still down here."

Above the houses, a weather vane spun. Its metal rooster pointed toward the hills.

Nell looked from the rooster to the shed.

She had an idea.

CHAPTER 2

A Very Thirsty Cloud

Her red kite hung behind the garden rake.

It had a long tail and a very fierce face Nell had drawn herself.

One eye was bigger than the other. That made it fiercer.

"You can ride this!"

"Does it bite?" asked Grumble.

"Only pretend."

Grandma found an old mitten. Nell tied it below the kite, with its thumb sticking out like a tiny balcony.

"Your very own cloud carriage," she said.

They carried everything to the open grass beyond the vegetable beds. Grandma brought the kite string. Nell brought the kite.

Grumble brought himself, in the saucer.

Nell ran.

The kite flapped once and flopped onto the grass.

She ran faster.

The kite flapped twice and flopped onto a cabbage.

"Perhaps it is tired," Grumble suggested.

Grandma studied the still trees.

"The evening breeze will come. We've time to get ready."

While they waited, Nell put Grumble beside the garden tap.

"I'll fetch the string winder. Don't wander."

"I am excellent at staying put," said Grumble.

A drop fell from the tap.

Plip.

Grumble licked it.

Another drop fell.

Plip.

He licked that too.

Then he tucked himself underneath the drip, opened his mouth, and looked extremely pleased.

By the time Nell came back, the saucer had disappeared.

So had the tap.

In their place sat a cloud the size of a small armchair.

"Grumble?"

"I was thirsty."

"You were bread-roll-sized!"

"I was bread-roll-sized and thirsty."

Nell pushed one hand into his fluff and found the tap. She turned it tight.

Grandma arrived with the wheelbarrow.

Between them, they rolled Grumble into it.

His eyebrows drooped over the handles.

"Can you float?" Nell asked.

Grumble strained. The wheelbarrow squeaked.

"No."

"Can you fit in the mitten?"

He looked at the mitten. He looked at himself.

"Perhaps just an eyebrow."

Nell sat on the grass.

"How do we make you small again?"

"Rain," said Grumble. "Pocket storms soak water up. A rumble shakes it out."

"Then rumble!"

Grumble sank into the wheelbarrow until only his eyes showed.

CHAPTER 3

The Wrong Sort of Thunder

"I would rather not."

Nell waited.

A bee visited a bean flower. Grandma untangled the kite string.

"My thunder is wrong," Grumble said at last.

"Wrong how?"

"Other storms go BOOM. Or CRASH. My cousin can rattle every saucepan in a kitchen."

He pulled his eyebrows over his eyes.

"Once, I thundered above a pond. Six ducks answered."

Nell pressed her lips together very hard.

"You can try with just me here," she said.

Grumble glanced at Grandma.

Grandma turned toward the beans and began humming to them.

Grumble took a breath. He puffed his cheeks. His belly wobbled.

"PIP!"

It sounded like a rubber duck being sat on.

A laugh popped out of Nell before she could catch it.

Grumble turned away.

One drop slid off his chin.

Nell's laugh stopped.

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean to laugh."

Grumble said nothing.

Nell picked a blade of grass and twisted it around her finger.

"It surprised me," she said. "But you asked for help, and I laughed. I'm sorry."

From behind the beans came a gentle clatter.

Grandma had knocked her spoon against the watering can.

Tink. Tonk.

Nell looked up.

Then she looked at Grumble.

"Would you like some other noises to go with yours?"

"What sort of noises?"

Nell borrowed the spoon and tapped the watering can.

Tink. Tonk. Tink-tink. Tonk.

Grumble lifted one eyebrow.

"That's a peculiar noise."

"It's a watering can. It hasn't practiced."

She held out the spoon.

"You can choose the beat."

Grumble listened to the can, then tapped its side with one fluffy point.

Tonk. Tonk. TINK.

Grandma fetched a saucepan and two wooden spoons.
"I was going to cook peas," she said. "They can wait."
She played Grumble's beat.
Tonk. Tonk. TINK.

Nell joined in on the watering can.
Over the fence, Mr. Moss's head appeared.
"Is that a band?"
"Possibly," said Nell.
"Needs a biscuit tin."
He disappeared.
A moment later, a biscuit tin rose above the fence.
Then Mr. Moss rose behind it.

CHAPTER 4

The Garden Band

Next door, the twins heard the tin and hurried over with two empty flowerpots.

The dog followed, carrying a squeaky bone.

Nell checked with Grumble.

"Is this too many people?"

He peered over the wheelbarrow.

Grandma held her spoons ready. The twins waited with their hands above the pots.

Nobody played.

Grumble straightened one fluffy point.

"The dog can stay," he said.

Then he lifted the other point.

"And everyone else."

"From the beginning," said Grumble.

Tonk. Tonk. TINK.

The saucepan clonked. The flowerpots plonked. The biscuit tin went RATTLE-ATTLE-ATTLE.

The dog bit his bone.

SQUEAK.

Grumble blinked at him.

The dog wagged.

Grumble took a breath.

"Pip."

A few drops spotted the grass.

Nell kept the beat steady. She watched Grumble's little points rise and fall.

He took another breath.

"PIP!"

Rain pattered out of the wheelbarrow.

Grumble's eyebrows bobbed.

"PIP-pip-PIP!"

The twins added a plonk. Mr. Moss shook his tin. Grandma put the saucepan on her head and tapped the bottom.

Nell missed a beat because she was staring at Grandma.

"Keeps my hair dry," Grandma said.

Grumble gave such a loud PIP that the dog answered.

SQUEAK!

This time Grumble laughed first.

The rain made a widening puddle under the wheelbarrow.

Beside it, Grandma's bean plants stood in dry, cracked soil.

"Can we take the music to the beans?" Nell asked.

Grumble peered down.

"I believe this shower is available for bookings."

Grandma lifted the handles.

Nell walked beside Grumble, playing the watering can. The twins followed. Mr. Moss brought up the rear.

The dog marched in the middle as if the whole thing had been his idea.

They watered the beans.

PIP-pip-PIP.

They watered the carrots.

PIP-pip-PIP.

They watered a very dusty garden gnome.

"He's been needing that," said Grandma.

Grumble grew smaller as they went. First armchair-sized. Then cushion-sized. Then teapot-sized.

At bread-roll-sized, he rose out of the wheelbarrow and settled on Nell's shoulder.

His rain stopped.

"Oh," he said. "I can see the gnome's ears from here. They are dreadful."

CHAPTER 5

A Ride in the Sky

A breeze brushed Nell's cheek.

The bean leaves rustled.

Above the garden wall, the weather vane swung toward the hills again.

Grumble looked up.

His family stretched across the pink sky. They were nearly at the hilltops.

"Now," he whispered.

Nell set down the watering can and ran for the kite.

The band followed, clattering.

The dog ran too.

"You won't fit in the mitten," she told him.

He brought his bone anyway.

The grass was damp and the kite string had wriggled into a knot.

Nell pulled one loop.

The knot got bigger.

She pulled another.

The knot got meaner.

Grumble's family drifted on.

"I'll pull harder," Nell said.

Grandma crouched beside her.

"Hold this bit loose for me."

Nell made her fingers loosen. Grandma slipped the string back through itself.

The knot fell open.

Nell let out the breath she had been holding.

They checked the mitten's strings. Nell tucked Grumble inside.

His eyebrows stuck out at the top.

"Comfortable?"

"My left side is in the thumb. Otherwise, yes."

Nell slipped her spoon into her pocket.

Grandma carried the kite across the open grass. Nell held the string winder.

The breeze lifted the red tail.

"Ready?" called Grandma.

Nell looked up at the enormous sky and gripped the winder.

"Ready!"

"Go!" called Grandma.

Grandma let go.

Nell ran.

The kite skipped, dipped, and rose.

It climbed above the beanpoles. Above the garden wall. Above the chimney that had smelled of toast.

The string tugged Nell's hands.

She slowed and planted her feet.
Grandma stood close beside her.

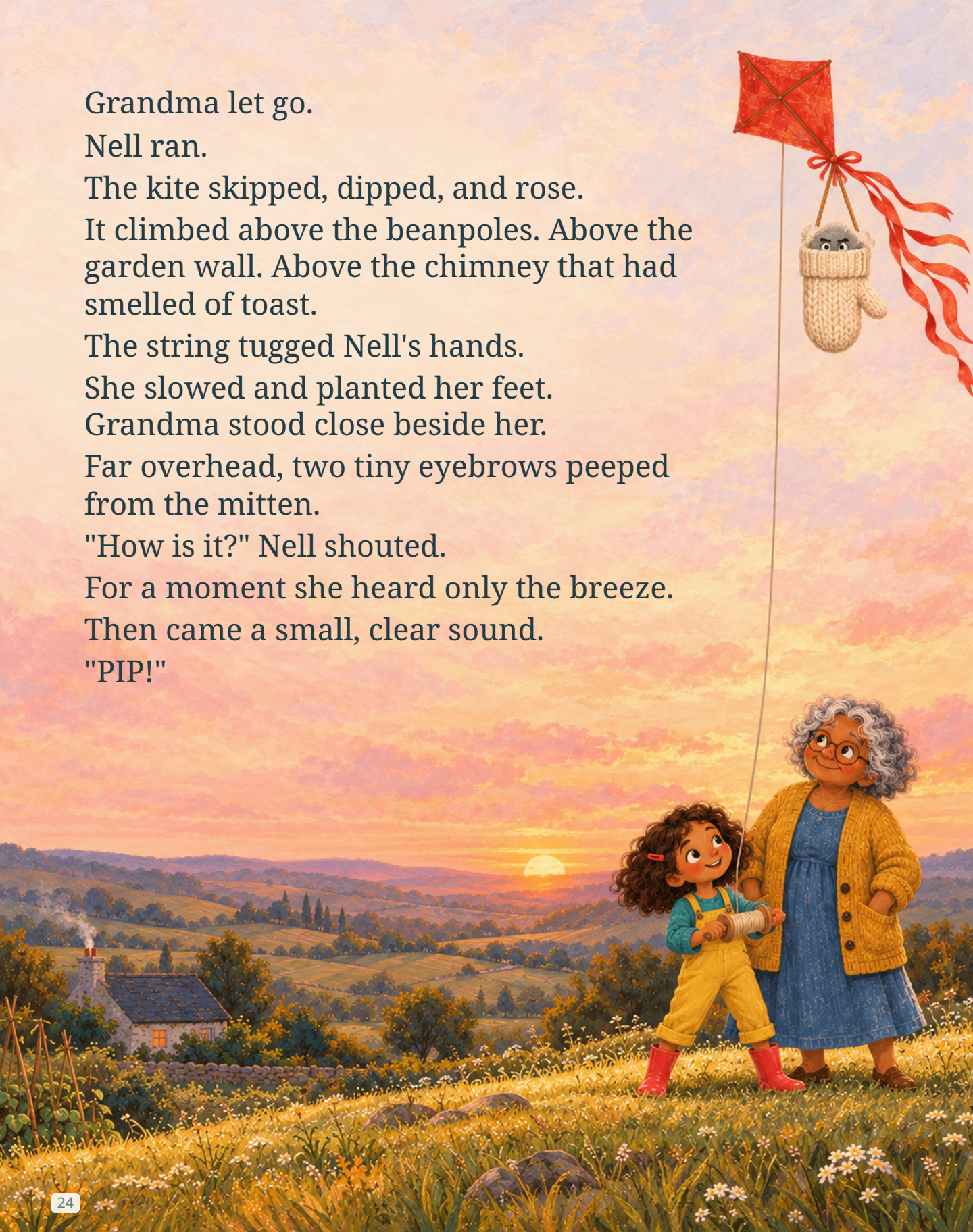
Far overhead, two tiny eyebrows peeped from the mitten.

"How is it?" Nell shouted.

For a moment she heard only the breeze.

Then came a small, clear sound.

"PIP!"



Grumble climbed onto the mitten's thumb.

The high wind ruffled his edges.

Nell watched him stretch one fluffy point toward his family, then pull it back.

He was holding on tightly.

"Do you think he's frightened?" she asked.

Grandma watched the little gray shape.

"It's a big step off a mitten."

Nell wished she could put her hand underneath him.

Instead, she pulled the wooden spoon from her pocket.

CHAPTER 6

Pip-pip-PIP!

She tapped the string winder.

Tonk. Tonk. TINK.

Grandma joined in on her saucepan.

Mr. Moss rattled his tin. The twins plonked their pots. The dog squeezed his bone with great care.

The red kite pulled against the sky.

Grumble stood taller on the mitten's thumb.

He puffed his cheeks.

"PIP-pip-PIP!"

From beyond the hill came an answer.

"POM-pom-POM!"

Another voice went, "Brrrumble!"

And a third went, quite distinctly, "HICCUP."

Grumble jumped.

For one breath he hung beneath the kite, a small gray comma in the pink sky.

Then the wind caught him.

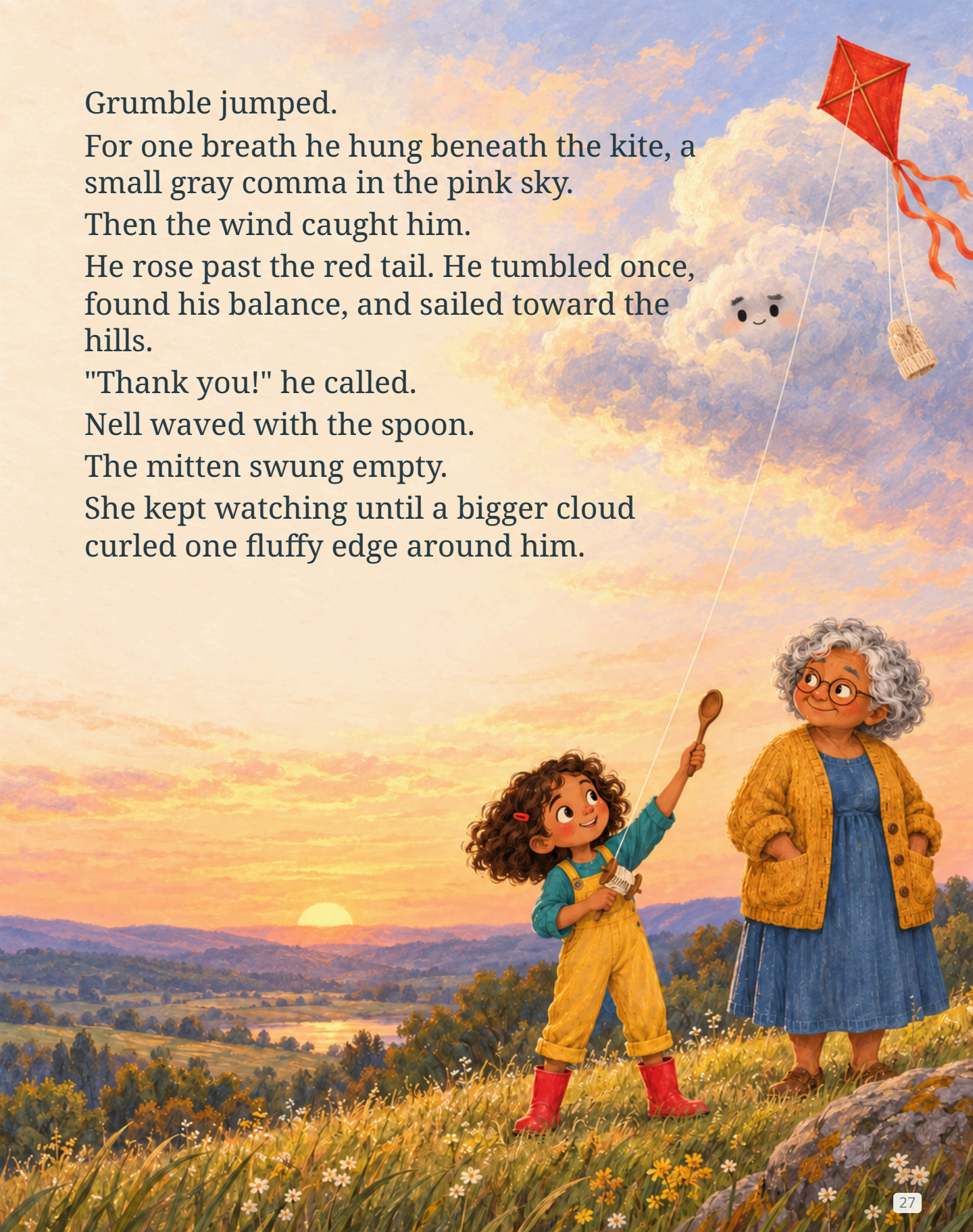
He rose past the red tail. He tumbled once, found his balance, and sailed toward the hills.

"Thank you!" he called.

Nell waved with the spoon.

The mitten swung empty.

She kept watching until a bigger cloud curled one fluffy edge around him.



They wound in the kite together.

Mr. Moss opened his biscuit tin. It contained three biscuits and rather a lot of crumbs.

Grandma fetched more from the kitchen.

The twins shared theirs with the dog. The dog ate the crumbs too, just to be helpful.

Nell sat on the overturned wheelbarrow with the mitten in her lap.

Its thumb was still a little damp.

She tucked one finger inside and looked toward the hills.

At bedtime, Nell lined up her boots beneath the window.

She checked them both.

One pebble. No weather.

Grandma came to say good night. She had washed her hair, which turned out to be a little wet after all.

"Should I leave the window open?" Nell asked.

"A crack, if you like."

Nell hung the mitten on the latch.

Then she got into bed and listened.

For a while, nothing happened.

Then three drops tapped the windowsill.

Tonk. Tonk. TINK.

Nell sat up.

Far above the house, something small and fluffy crossed the moon.

"PIP-pip-PIP!"

Nell tapped the bedpost in reply.

From next door came a sleepy squeak.

The dog had joined in.

Nell snuggled under her blanket.

In the morning, her left boot was dry.

Her right boot contained exactly one tiny rainbow.